CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



THE FUTURE BET

- Set up five university townships near major industrial corridors
- These clusters of knowledge and skills will connect with job opportunities and help further regional specialisations

The Skilling Corridors

New university towns near industrial corridors would emphasise latest research in future skills and fuse it with industry exposure and specific employment needs

By **KAUSHIK DEKA**

thrive because they are embedded in wider economic and social networks.

The budget seeks to link education to emerging sectors through initiatives such as AVGC (animation, visual effects, gaming and comics) labs in schools and colleges. Binding all these strands together, the proposed High-Powered Education to Employment and Enterprise Standing Committee is tasked with aligning education, skills and emerging tech, particularly AI, with future labour markets. Education is positioned as the first link in the pipeline that runs from learning to services exports, employment and enterprise-creation.

Education spending in the budget has risen to Rs 1.39 lakh crore from about Rs 1.34 lakh crore the previous year, and skill development to Rs 9,885.8 crore from a budget estimate of Rs 6,100 crore in 2025–26. However, in 2025–26, education allocations were cut by nearly Rs 6,700 crore in the revised estimates. Ironically, given the importance accorded to it, skill development spending was reduced by more than half.

Education commands 2.6 per cent of total Union expenditure of Rs 53.47 lakh crore. When skill development is added, combined spending reaches about 2.8 per cent, unchanged from the previous fiscal.

Overall, Budget 2026 strengthens existing structures and encourages limited innovation but falls short of the investment needed to transform learning outcomes. ■



"If designed as shared platforms rather than silos, university townships can strengthen industry-academia links and accelerate National Education Policy 2020 by translating ideas into jobs and products"

— MAMIDALA JAGADESH KUMAR
Former Chairman, UGC and Vice-chancellor, JNU